flow while from the other end Srinath picked up wickets at regular intervals.

At no time during the chase were South Africa in with a chance. We kept up the pressure and managed to bowl them out for 105 in just thirty-nine overs, recording a famous victory. It was the high point of my captaincy; the plan to use Srinath from one end had worked really well. Hansie Cronje walked up to me after the game and confessed that he had been caught off-guard. He had expected me to employ spinners and had a strategy in place to negotiate the turning ball on a wearing pitch. He did not have a plan for Srinath, and by the time he had come to terms with our tactics the match was over.

The other thing I tried out in that Test match for the first time, something that served India well for a decade and a half, was to get Rahul Dravid to bat at number three and Sourav Ganguly at five, which was not an obvious decision at the time. Both had had great starts to their careers in England batting in other positions. Sourav had scored two consecutive hundreds batting at number three. In his third Test against Australia, which was the first of my captaincy, he once again batted in that position and scored 66 in the first innings and was unbeaten on 21 in the second. He was full of confidence and was keen to continue batting at three. Rahul too had scored consecutive fifties in England in his first two Tests and was looking good at number five. However, I felt that by changing the batting order I could get the best out of each of them in the long run.

Sourav was a boundary-hitter and liked playing his shots from the start of his innings. He was flamboyant and more attacking and I felt his style was more suited to number five. Rahul on the other hand played within himself at the start of his innings and was comfortable leaving a lot of deliveries outside the off stump. That’s an important ability for a number-three batsman. The two had very different strengths and I knew that both were terrific players and had the talent to serve India for many years. With Rahul at three and Sourav at five, I felt the team would have a better balance, especially in overseas conditions. Though we reverted to Sourav at three and Rahul at five for the deciding third Test of this series and the first two Tests in South Africa shortly afterwards, we repeated the experiment in the third and final Test of that series at Johannesburg in January 1997. It worked very well and became a permanent fixture of India’s batting for over a decade.